SPECIAL SECTION

DEMOCRACY INTERCEPTED

Did platform feeds sow the seeds of deep divisions during the 2020 US presidential election?

By **Ekeoma E. Uzogara**

The advent of social media forever changed how we consume news. At least half of Americans rely on it for news, and Facebook (owned by parent company Meta) is the most popular. Meta's Facebook and Instagram platforms are funded through advertisements and generate more revenue when users spend more time on their platforms. To make platforms alluring and increase screen time, tech companies operate on business models that incentivize algorithms that are designed to elevate eye-catching content to the top of users' feeds—content that captures attention and may go "viral" by stimulating "engagement" through comments, likes, and resharing.

But can a business model that prioritizes "engagement algorithms" pose a threat to democracy? Algorithms glean information about users' interests to give them more of what they want to see. This could lead to polarization when algorithms curate emotionally evocative content that features divisive or inflammatory language. Whether this process has consequences at voting booths remains hotly contested. In a properly functioning democracy, people must form political beliefs from accurate news, but social media's architecture may leave partisans siloed in biased news sources, exposed to misinformation, and surrounded by like-minded individuals that reinforce their attitudes. Proposed solutions include the suppression of reshared content or replacement of "engagement algorithms" with others that indiscriminately recommend content in reverse chronological order.

In this special issue, these possible controls are explored through a pioneering collaboration between independent academics and Meta's researchers, who had access to Meta's internal data during the 2020 US presidential election. Research herein examines pressing questions around the impact of Meta's platforms on polarization, political knowledge, attitudes, and behavior and also discusses trade-offs during this rare collaboration. Tech companies have a public responsibility to understand how design features of platforms may affect users and, ultimately, democracy. The time is now to motivate substantive changes and reforms.

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VOTE

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